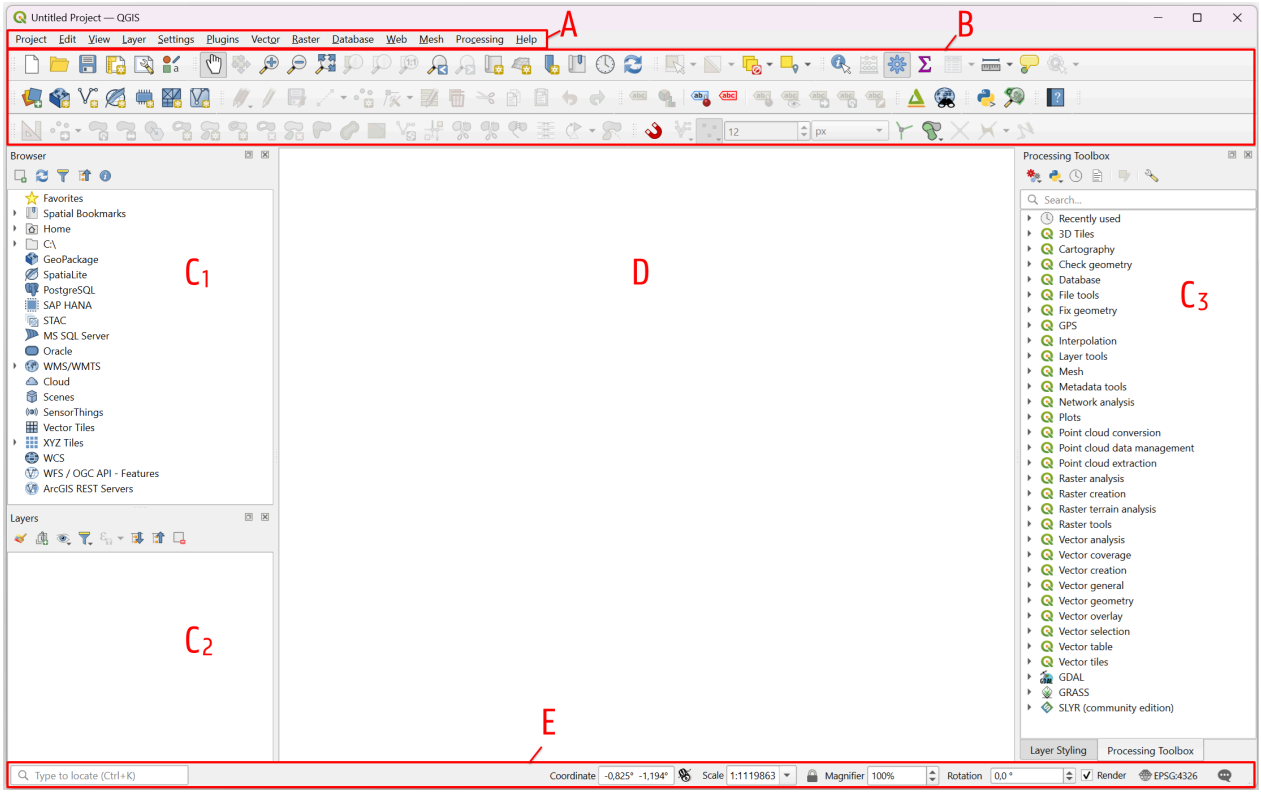
1.2 QGIS interface

When you open the software for the first time after installation, you will see the following screen:



The main window consists of several elements. Some of them are discussed in more detail later in this learning path; here we give a general overview.

A: Menu bar

In the menu bar, hierarchical menus give you access to a wide range of QGIS configuration options and functions: from personalising the interface to running analyses on your data.

B: Toolbars

The toolbars give you direct access to important and frequently used functions. Many of these are also available through the menu bar, but here they are quicker to reach and save you some mouse clicks. GIS is used for a wide variety of purposes, and not everyone needs the same tools: someone who digitises historical maps uses other functions far more often than someone who analyses statistics. That is why you can choose which toolbars are shown and where they are placed: tick the ones you want under *View* ▸ *Toolbars*, then drag them with your mouse to where you want them.

Examples of frequently used toolbars are:

Project toolbar	e.g. creating a new project and saving it
Map navigation toolbar	e.g. pan tool and zoom options
Attributes toolbar	e.g. looking up attribute information (identifying features, opening the attribute table)

Selection toolbar	e.g. selecting and deselecting features
Data source manager toolbar	e.g. adding new data to the project and creating new data layers
Digitizing toolbar	e.g. editing and adding geometries

C: Panels

Panels are special **widgets** (small windows inside the QGIS window that you can show, hide, move or dock) that let you use certain functions in your GIS environment through a visual interface. As with the toolbars, you can choose which panels are visible and where exactly they are shown: under *View*▸*Panels* you can switch each panel on or off. If a panel you need (for example one from the table below) is not visible on your screen, you can open it there.

C1	**Browser panel** (Explorer)	The Browser panel gives you quick access to all your data sources. With this widget you can easily view and import local files on your computer as well as data on a server or in a database.
C2	**Layers panel** (Table of contents)	Here you see an overview of all layers that have been imported into your GIS project. You can choose which of these layers are (in)visible in the map canvas and in which order they are shown. The *Layers* panel gives you access to the advanced configuration options of the different layers.
C3	**Processing toolbox**	In the Processing Toolbox, the available tools for analysis and data processing are grouped in thematic groups that you can expand.

D: Map canvas

The most eye-catching part of the interface is the map canvas. Here you can view a spatial visualisation of your geographic data (layers). The map canvas is an interactive window: as a user, you can zoom in and out, move around the map, look up information about features and select data.

> ℹ See also
>
> Zooming and panning are explained on Navigating the map canvas.

E: Status bar

In the status bar you will find general information about your map (e.g. the coordinates your mouse is hovering over, the coordinate system used, the scale). You can also rotate your map there, so that north is no longer at the top. Finally, this bar also shows status messages about actions that are running or have finished.

> ℹ See also
>
> The status bar is explained in more detail on The status bar.